

DHO Lunch and Learn

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U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs

Veterans Health Administration
Digital Health Office

Intro to Human Centered Design (HCD)

February 18, 2025

Agenda

- What is HCD?
- Core Principles & Process
- HCD in Action
- HCD in Healthcare
- Communities of Practice
- Q&A

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Humanizing Technology, One Experience at a Time



Pamela Hastings,
Acting Director of
Research and Design
Digital Health Experience
and Product, Digital
Health Office

I help organizations transform their ways of working to be human-centered using design thinking.

I believe it is always critical to ask
What are we solving?
Who are we solving for?



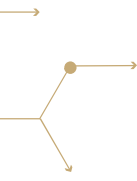
Human-Centered Design is a **problem-solving methodology** that places **people at the heart** of the design process, ensuring solutions are tailored to their needs, behaviors, and contexts.



“

*Good design, when done well, becomes invisible.
It's only when it's done poorly that we notice it.*

- *Jared Spool*



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HCD is collaborative

HCD is a mindset

Aligning digital tools with user needs.

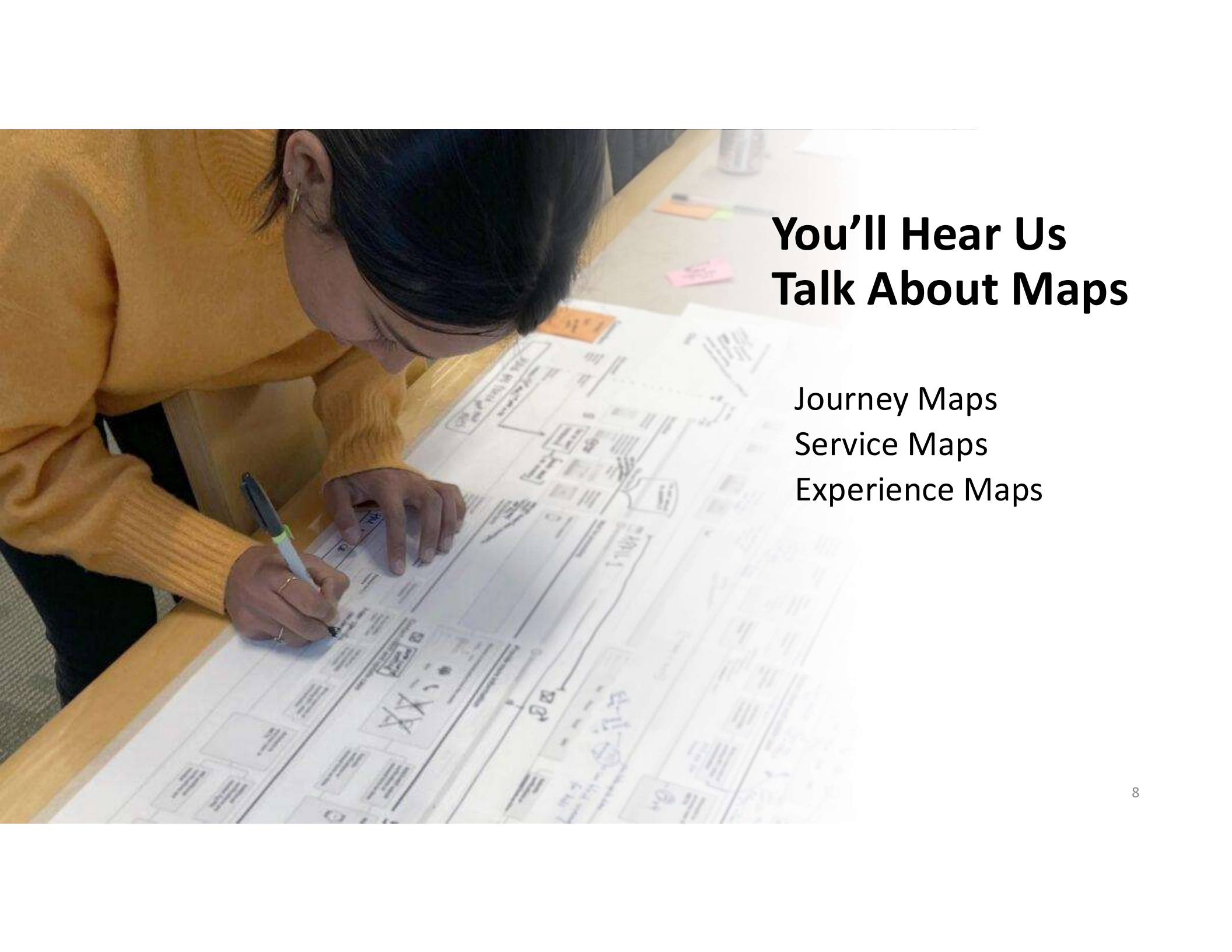
HCD is a partnership

Collaborating with business needs and system constraints

HCD is a practice

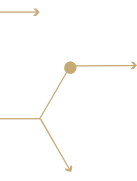
Designing, prototyping, and testing with users to continuously improve.



A person with dark hair, wearing a yellow sweater, is leaning over a large table. They are using a blue and yellow marker to write on a large, complex diagram spread across the table. The diagram appears to be a service map or journey map, with various boxes, lines, and handwritten notes. There are also some sticky notes on the table. The background is a plain white wall.

You'll Hear Us Talk About Maps

Journey Maps
Service Maps
Experience Maps



Why is HCD Important

Empowers Users:

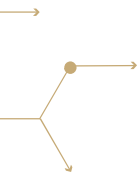
Ensures solutions resonate with real people by addressing their pain points and aspirations.

Drives Innovation:

With insights from real world context – humanizes technology and complex challenges.

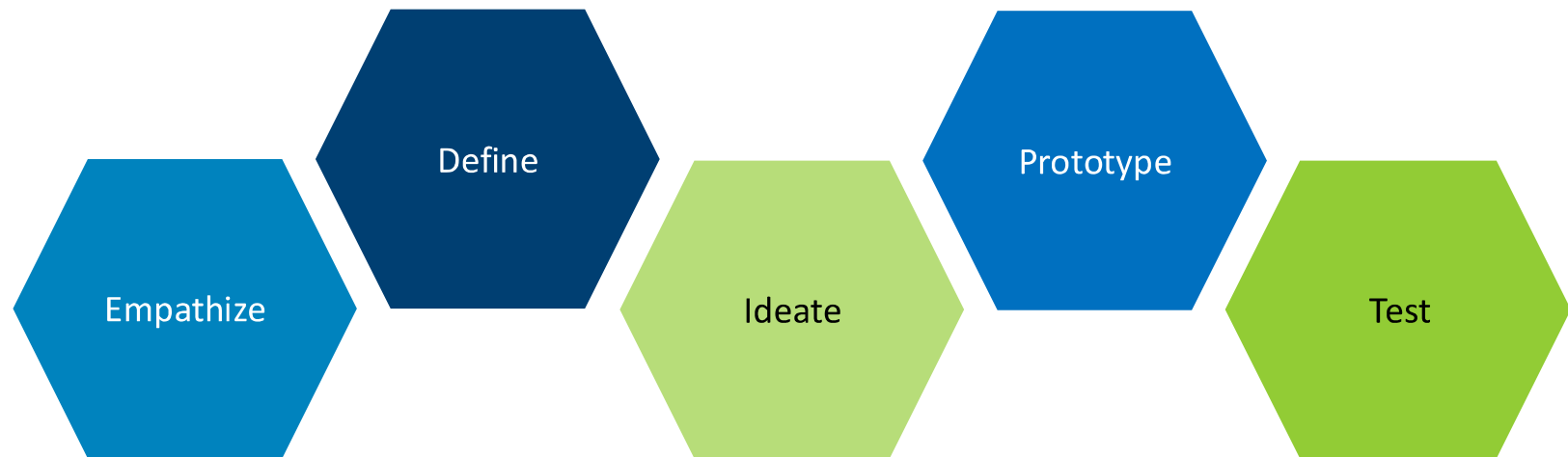
Improves Outcomes:

Leads to more intuitive, accessible, and sustainable solutions.



Human-Centered Design Process

Involving the voice of the user early and often



HCD in Action

Deep understanding of needs to drive innovation

Simplifying USDA's free lunch application saved \$600M over five years while improving user experience.

Redesigning USAJOBS reduced help desk tickets by 30%, enhancing usability for millions of users annually.

Source: [Digital.gov — Guidance on building better digital services in government](#)



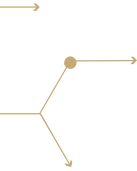


HCD & Healthcare

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HCD in a Healthcare Context

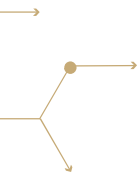
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How might we apply Human-Centered Design (HCD) to healthcare delivery from a care team perspective?

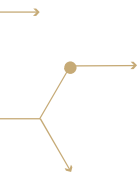
Where are opportunities to improve their experience and the quality of care they provide.



HCD in a Healthcare Context

Enhancing Usability and Efficiency of Digital Tools

- **Electronic Health Records (EHRs):**
Many clinicians face frustration with EHR systems, which are often time-consuming and unintuitive. Working closely with care teams, we can align digital tools with their needs.
- **Interoperability:** HCD helps us diagnose integration friction points and create seamless systems that allow clinicians to access and share patient information efficiently, reducing delays and errors.



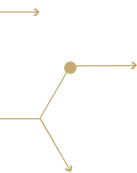
HCD in a Healthcare Context

Addressing Burnout

Workflow Optimization:

HCD focuses on understanding clinicians' day-to-day challenges, such as fragmented care coordination or excessive administrative tasks.

Redesigning workflows or processes can reduce stress, free up time, leading to a better patient care experience.



HCD in a Healthcare Context

Improving Care Coordination

- **Team Collaboration Tools:** HCD can enhance tools that facilitate communication between multidisciplinary teams, ensuring smoother transitions of care and reducing miscommunication.
- **Support Services Integration:** By involving clinicians in the design process, systems can be developed to better synchronize with diagnostic labs or radiology services, minimizing critical delays in patient care

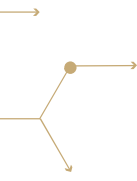
HCD in a Healthcare Context

Co-Creation with Clinicians

Involving clinicians early in the design process ensures solutions are practical and address real-world challenges. For example:

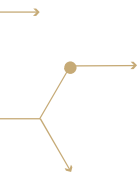
- At Kaiser Permanente, nurses participated in redesigning pain management protocols using HCD principles, improving both patient outcomes and their work experience. *1
- Collaborative workshops with clinicians have been used to prototype processes that enhance value-based care models while reducing inefficiencies. *2

1. NLM: [The Application of Human-Centered Design Approaches in Health](#)
2. [Paving the Way for Value-Based Care using human-centered design](#)



Benefits of HCD for Care Teams

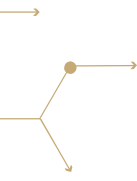
- Reduced frustration with technology
- Improved efficiency in workflows
- Better emotional well-being and reduced burnout
- Enhanced collaboration within care teams
- Greater satisfaction with their role in patient care



Problem Framing Activity

Defining a problem statement

As a **[Type of User]**, I need to **[Desired Action or Feature]**
so that I can achieve **[Desired Outcome]**.



Problem Framing Activity

Defining a problem statement

[Type of User]: Describe who is facing the problem.

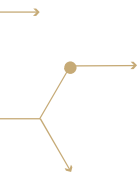
Example: "frequent traveler"

[Desired Action or Feature]: What does the user need?

Examples: "find the best flight deals"

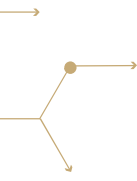
[Desired Outcome]: Why does the user need this? What do they hope to achieve?

Examples: "save money on travel"



Discussion

- How easy or hard was it to write a problem statement?
- What questions came up for you?



Key Takeaways

- HCD is about *designing with people*, not just for them.
- It requires empathy, collaboration, and iteration.
- By focusing on human needs, HCD fosters innovative, sustainable solutions that make a real impact

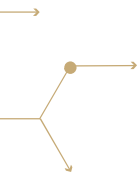


Communities of Practice

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HCD Across VA

Communities of practice

[VA Digital Service Handbook | Digital Standards](#)

[USDS Playbook](#)

[Veteran Experience Office](#)

[Veteran Experience Services Unmet Needs](#)

[Human Systems Integration Resources](#)

[OCC Human-Centered Design Work](#)



Questions?

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Thank you!

Please take our short pulse check to provide your feedback and input for future sessions

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